

I've got mail. Now what?

There was a kingdom, somewhere far away, which had a troubled king. He was increasingly nagged by a suspicion that his country folk were lacking in civic duty. To put his mind to rest, he placed a rock in the middle of their mainstreet. Days passed by as he watched citizens stumble upon, jump over, swerved from and curse the wretched stone (and the authorities). Everyone thought someone else would move the stone.

Harvard's Greg Barron and Indiana University's Eldad Yechiam are in a similar state of thought, after a study of theirs showed that most online requests get ignored because everybody thought somebody else would reply to them.

They have traced this problem to what they call the "volunteer dilemma", because of which response levels

decrease with an increasing group size. The key, according to the researchers, lies in delegating the responsibility to respond. They suggest sending personalised e-mails instead of multiple recipients.

And in a result that may not surprise many, the duo also found out that requests under a female name had a significantly higher response ratio, than those from men.

It would seem that this study would greatly help the booming call centre and IT helpdesks industry, which are often inundated with e-mail requests. But we have a question: Have spammers already perfected this art?

Incidentally, have you ever had a bad experience with IT helpdesks not responding to your queries? Send us your experiences at noreply@thinkdigit.com.

Father of the Web entangled in a million Euros

Thirteen years after he created the World Wide Web, Tim Berners-Lee was awarded the Millennium Technology Prize by the Finnish Technology Awards Foundation.

Berners-Lee, voted as one of the top 100 minds of the 20th



century by Time magazine, won the 1 million Euros (Rs 5.3 crore) award for devising a system to organise, link and browse Net pages—a development that revolutionised the Internet.

Surprisingly, when Sir Tim (he was knighted in 2003), created the hypertext program, he never commercialised his work. Instead, he worked on expanding the use of the Net as a channel for free expression and collaboration.

Pardon the cliché, but the rest is now history.

Sir Tim currently heads up the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in Boston, where he is now based as an academic.

Well, better late than never, we say!

snapshot

28: average number of items of spyware in one PC

Source: www.theregister.co.uk

redalert

20 Vulnerabilities in Windows

Microsoft has identified 20 new vulnerabilities across various versions of Windows, some of them highly critical.

Most of these can cause execution of arbitrary code. Apart from this, a weakness in LDT—Local Descriptor Table—and an error in Virtual DOS Machine (VDM) can be exploited to access protected memory.

In another vulnerability, an attacker may send a specially-crafted reply to messages forwarded over HTTP Proxy components, and cause a Denial of Service.

Outlook Express, too, is vulnerable. Outlook and Internet Explorer can also be used as attack vectors.

Microsoft Jet Database Engine has also been found to have a vulnerability that can be exploited to execute arbitrary code with the privileges of an affected application.

Patches for are available through Windows Update.

Another ActiveX Vulnerability

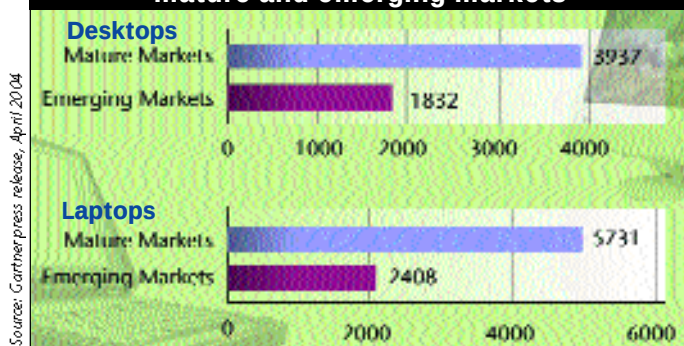
When someone visits www.pandasoftware.com for online virus-scanning for the first time, the Panda ActiveScan Control gets installed by Panda ActiveScan on the user's system. This ActiveX control has a boundary error in the 'ReportHebrew' object. Following this, a heap overflow can occur.

Exploitation of this can allow execution of arbitrary code on the user's system.

The vulnerability has been corrected by Panda Software in an updated version of this ActiveX control.

statattack

Total Cost of Ownership of computers in mature and emerging markets



US Consumer satisfaction levels with portals

